Information Geometry of the Quantum-Classical Transition in Biological Systems

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Abstract

Decoherence drives the quantum-to-classical transition, but its information-geometric structure—the precise dimensional and metric changes it imposes on quantum state space—has not been quantified in the Bures/Fisher–Rao framework. We show that decoherence is a dimensional collapse: the dephasing channel maps a (d^2-1)-dimensional quantum manifold onto the $(d-1)$-dimensional classical probability simplex, annihilating the d^2-d coherence directions while preserving the $d-1$ population dimensions. At diagonal states, the classical and quantum tangent subspaces are Bures-orthogonal. We compute the exact Bures principal angle θ_B between these subspaces at every full-rank qubit state, obtaining $\cos^2\theta_B = r_z^2 r_\perp^2/[(1-r_\perp^2)(1-r_z^2)]$, where r_z is the population imbalance and $r_\perp$ the coherence magnitude. For $d \geq 3$, Bures-orthogonality fails whenever a nonzero coherence has a decoupled spectator index, and a perturbative formula quantifies the departure. We apply this framework to the Fenna–Matthews–Olson photosynthetic complex ($d = 7$), where decoherence collapses 48 quantum dimensions to 6 classical dimensions. Computing the six Bures principal angles as a function of dephasing strength, we find that the quantum-classical transition is rapid: at physiological

dephasing rates ($\gamma \sim 50$–$200\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$), all principal angles exceed 89° and the system is geometrically nearly classical, with strong quantum-classical mixing confined to much weaker dephasing ($\gamma \lesssim 10\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$).

1 Introduction

The quantum-to-classical transition mediated by decoherence [1, 2, 3, 4] is not merely a theoretical curiosity in biological systems—it is functionally relevant. Photosynthetic complexes exploit quantum coherence during energy transfer on femtosecond timescales [5], and optimal transport efficiency occurs at intermediate dephasing rates, a phenomenon termed environment-assisted quantum transport (ENAQT) [6, 7, 8]. The quantum biology literature has established that partial decoherence can enhance biological function [9], but the geometric structure of this transition—how many degrees of freedom are destroyed, how cleanly classical information separates from quantum information, and what the dimensional architecture of intermediate regimes looks like—has not been quantified.

Information geometry provides the natural mathematical language for these questions. The quantum Fisher information matrix (QFIM) [10, 11] measures the dimensionality of distinguishable quantum states, and the Bures metric it induces [12, 13, 14] is the unique minimal monotone Riemannian metric on quantum state space. The classical Fisher–Rao metric [15, 16, 17] plays the analogous role for probability distributions. Despite the maturity of both decoherence theory and information geometry, these frameworks have not been combined to characterize the dimensional structure of the quantum-to-classical transition.

In this paper, we show that decoherence is a *dimensional collapse* in the information-geometric sense. A d-dimensional quantum system lives on a (d^2-1)-dimensional state manifold equipped with the Bures metric. Decoherence projects this manifold onto the $(d-1)$-dimensional classical probability simplex equipped with the Fisher–Rao metric. Specifically:

(Collapse.) The decoherence channel reduces the QFIM rank from d^2-1 to at most $d-1$ (Theorem 3.2), and the Bures metric restricts to the Fisher–Rao metric on Δ_{d-1} (Theorem 3.3). At full-rank diagonal states, the differential of the dephasing map is the Bures-orthogonal projector onto the classical tangent subspace (Theorem 3.4).

metry of the split.) We compute the exact Bures principal angle θ_B between the classical and quantum tangent subspaces at every full-rank qubit state (Theorem 3.5). For $d \geq 3$, Bures-orthogonality fails whenever a nonzero coherence has a decoupled spectator index (Theorem 3.9), and a perturbative formula quantifies the departure (Theorem 3.8).

(Application.) We apply the framework to the Fenna–Matthews–Olson (FMO) photosynthetic complex, where $d = 7$ sites yield a collapse from 48 to 6 information-geometric dimensions. Computing the six Bures principal angles as a function of dephasing strength, we find that at physiological dephasing rates the system is geometrically nearly classical, with the strong quantum-classical mixing regime lying at much weaker dephasing.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 establishes the information-geometric framework. Section 3 contains the core mathematical results. Section 4 derives the thermodynamic cost of dimensional collapse. Section 5 applies the framework to the FMO complex. Section 6 discusses implications, limitations, and connections to classical biological coherence.

2 Information-Geometric Framework

We establish the mathematical framework that makes "dimensional collapse" precise.

Definition 2.1 (Quantum state manifold)**.** The space of $d \times d$ density matrices,

$$\mathcal{M}_Q = \left\{\rho \in \mathbb{C}^{d\times d} : \rho \geq 0,\ \operatorname{Tr}\rho = 1\right\}, \tag{1}$$

is a real manifold of dimension $d^2 - 1$: a $d \times d$ Hermitian matrix has d^2 real parameters, the trace constraint removes one, leaving $d - 1$ populations and $d(d-1)$ coherences.

Definition 2.2 (Quantum Fisher information matrix)**.** Let $\rho(\theta)$ be a smooth parametric family of density matrices with $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^p$. The QFIM is the $p \times p$ matrix with entries

$$[F_Q]_{ij} = \mathrm{Tr}\Big[\rho\, \frac{L_i L_j + L_j L_i}{2}\Big], \tag{2}$$

where L_i is the symmetric logarithmic derivative (SLD) defined by $\partial_i \rho = (\rho L_i + L_i \rho)/2$. For full-rank ρ with eigenbasis $\rho = \sum_k p_k |k\rangle\langle k|$, the matrix elements are $(L_i)_{mn} = 2(\partial_i \rho)_{mn}/(p_m + p_n)$.

The QFIM defines the Bures–Helstrom metric $ds^2_{\mathrm{Bures}} = \frac{1}{4}\sum_{ij}[F_Q]_{ij}\, d\theta^i\, d\theta^j$, the unique minimal monotone Riemannian metric on quantum state space [14, 11]. By Petz's monotonicity theorem, for any CPTP map Λ:

$$F_Q\Big(\Lambda[\rho(\theta)]\Big) \leq F_Q\Big(\rho(\theta)\Big) \tag{3}$$

in the Löwner order—quantum channels cannot increase statistical distinguishability.

Definition 2.3 (Effective quantum dimensionality)**.** Given a QFIM F_Q with eigenvalues $\lambda_1 \geq \cdots \geq \lambda_p \geq 0$, the effective quantum dimensionality is the participation ratio

$$D^Q_{\mathrm{eff}} = \frac{\Big(\sum_i \lambda_i\Big)^2}{\sum_i \lambda_i^2}, \tag{4}$$

ranging from 1 (single dominant direction) to p (all directions equally estimable). D^Q_{eff} is a coordinate-dependent diagnostic: the rank of F_Q is invariant, but the participation ratio depends on the parameterization. The main theorems of this paper depend only on rank, kernel structure, and metric properties.

3 Decoherence as Dimensional Projection

We now show that decoherence acts as a geometric projection, annihilating the $d^2 - d$ off-diagonal directions and collapsing quantum state space onto the $(d-1)$-dimensional classical probability simplex.

Definition 3.1 (Decoherence channel)**.** Fix an orthonormal pointer basis $\{|k\rangle\}_{k=1}^{d}$. The complete dephasing channel is

$$\Lambda_{\text{dec}}(\rho) = \sum_{k=1}^{d} |k\rangle\langle k|\, \rho\, |k\rangle\langle k|, \tag{5}$$

setting all off-diagonal elements to zero: $[\Lambda_{\text{dec}}(\rho)]_{kl} = \delta_{kl}\, \langle k|\rho|k\rangle$.

Theorem 3.2 (Dimensional collapse)**.** *Let $\mathcal{M}_Q$ be the quantum state manifold of a d-dimensional system* ($\dim \mathcal{M}_Q = d^2 - 1$)*. The decoherence channel Λ_{dec} maps $\mathcal{M}_Q$ onto the classical probability simplex Δ_{d-1}* ($\dim \Delta_{d-1} = d - 1$)*. Specifically:*

(i) *The image $\Lambda_{\text{dec}}(\mathcal{M}_Q) = \Delta_{d-1}$.*

(ii) *The $d^2 - d$ off-diagonal parameters become unestimable: for any smooth parameterization $\theta = (\theta_{\text{diag}}, \theta_{\text{off}})$, the QFIM of $\Lambda_{\text{dec}}[\rho(\theta)]$ satisfies*

$$[F_Q(\Lambda_{\text{dec}}[\rho])]_{\alpha\beta} = 0 \quad \textit{whenever } \alpha \in \theta_{\text{off}} \textit{ or } \beta \in \theta_{\text{off}}. \tag{6}$$

In particular, $\operatorname{rank} F_Q(\Lambda_{\text{dec}}[\rho]) \leq d - 1$.

(iii) *The dimensional collapse ratio is*

$$\frac{\dim \Delta_{d-1}}{\dim \mathcal{M}_Q} = \frac{d-1}{d^2-1} = \frac{1}{d+1}, \tag{7}$$

which vanishes as $d \to \infty$.

Proof. Part (i): Λ_{dec} sends ρ to $\operatorname{diag}(\langle k|\rho|k\rangle)$, a point in Δ_{d-1}; every point in Δ_{d-1} is the image of some diagonal state. Part (iii) is arithmetic.

For Part (ii): the decohered state depends only on θ_{diag}, so $\partial\rho_{\text{dec}}/\partial\theta^{\alpha}_{\text{off}} = 0$, giving $L_\alpha = 0$ and hence $[F_Q]_{\alpha\beta} = 0$ whenever α or β is off-diagonal. The surviving diagonal block reduces to the classical Fisher information:

$$[F_Q]^{\text{diag}}_{ij} = \sum_{k=1}^{d} \frac{1}{p_k} \frac{\partial p_k}{\partial \theta^i_{\text{diag}}} \frac{\partial p_k}{\partial \theta^j_{\text{diag}}} = [F_{\text{cl}}]_{ij}, \tag{8}$$

which has rank at most $d-1$. $\square$

Theorem 3.3 (Metric restriction)**.** *Under Λ_{dec}, the Bures metric on $\mathcal{M}_Q$ restricts to the Fisher–Rao metric on Δ_{d-1}:*

$$ds^2_{\mathrm{Bures}}\Big|_{\Delta_{d-1}} = \frac{1}{4}\sum_{k=1}^{d}\frac{dp_k^2}{p_k} = \frac{1}{4}\,ds^2_{\text{Fisher-Rao}}. \tag{9}$$

Proof. For diagonal states, the SLD is diagonal: $\langle k|L_i|k\rangle = (\partial_i p_k)/p_k$. The Bures line element becomes $\frac{1}{4}\sum_k dp_k^2/p_k$, the Fisher–Rao metric [11]. $\square$

Theorem 3.4 (Orthogonal decomposition)**.** *Let $\rho = \mathrm{diag}(p_1,\ldots,p_d)$ be a full-rank diagonal state. The tangent space admits an orthogonal decomposition under the Bures metric:*

$$T_\rho\mathcal{M}_Q = T_\rho^{\mathrm{diag}} \oplus T_\rho^{\mathrm{off}}, \tag{10}$$

where T_ρ^{diag} is the $(d-1)$-dimensional traceless diagonal subspace and T_ρ^{off} is the (d^2-d)-dimensional off-diagonal Hermitian subspace. The differential $d\Lambda_{\mathrm{dec}}|_\rho$ acts as the identity on T_ρ^{diag} and as zero on T_ρ^{off}, so it is the g_B-orthogonal projector onto T_ρ^{diag}.

Proof. At a diagonal state, any traceless Hermitian X decomposes as $X = X_D + X_O$ (diagonal + off-diagonal). The SLD for a diagonal perturbation X_D is diagonal: $(L_{X_D})_{kk} = x_k/p_k$. The SLD for an off-diagonal perturbation X_O is off-diagonal: $(L_{X_O})_{mn} = 2z_{mn}/(p_m+p_n)$ for $m \neq n$. The anticommutator $\{L_{X_D}, L_{X_O}\}$ is off-diagonal (product of diagonal and off-diagonal matrices), so $\rho\{L_{X_D}, L_{X_O}\}$ is off-diagonal with zero trace:

$$g_B(X_D, X_O) = \frac{1}{4}\,\mathrm{Tr}\left[\rho\,\frac{\{L_{X_D}, L_{X_O}\}}{2}\right] = 0.$$

The dephasing channel preserves diagonal and annihilates off-diagonal perturbations, completing the identification as orthogonal projector. $\square$

3.1 The classical–quantum split away from the simplex

Theorem 3.4 establishes orthogonality at diagonal states. What happens at states carrying coherence? For qubits, a single principal angle characterizes the full relationship.

Theorem 3.5 (Bures separation angle)**.** *Let $\rho = (I + \mathbf{r} \cdot \boldsymbol{\sigma})/2$ be a full-rank qubit state ($|\mathbf{r}| < 1$) with coherence magnitude $r_\perp = \sqrt{r_x^2 + r_y^2}$ and population imbalance r_z. The principal angle θ_B between T_ρ^{diag} and T_ρ^{off} under the Bures metric satisfies*

$$\cos^2 \theta_B = \frac{r_z^2 r_\perp^2}{(1 - r_\perp^2)(1 - r_z^2)}. \tag{11}$$

Equivalently,

$$\sin^2 \theta_B = \frac{1 - |\mathbf{r}|^2}{(1 - r_\perp^2)(1 - r_z^2)}. \tag{12}$$

Proof. The Bures metric on qubit state space in Bloch coordinates is $g_{ij}^B = \frac{1}{4}[\delta_{ij} + r_i r_j/(1 - |\mathbf{r}|^2)]$. The principal angle is found by maximizing $g_B(\hat{e}_z, v)/(\|\hat{e}_z\| \cdot \|v\|)$ over $v \in T_\rho^{\mathrm{off}}$. The maximizer is $v_\perp = (r_x, r_y, 0)/r_\perp$. Computing:

$$\begin{aligned} g_B(\hat{e}_z, v_\perp) &= \frac{r_z r_\perp}{4(1 - |\mathbf{r}|^2)}, \\ g_B(\hat{e}_z, \hat{e}_z) &= \frac{1 - r_\perp^2}{4(1 - |\mathbf{r}|^2)}, \\ g_B(v_\perp, v_\perp) &= \frac{1 - r_z^2}{4(1 - |\mathbf{r}|^2)}. \end{aligned}$$

The squared cosine follows; the sine formula uses $(1 - r_\perp^2)(1 - r_z^2) - r_z^2 r_\perp^2 = 1 - |\mathbf{r}|^2$. □

Corollary 3.6 (Structure of the classical–quantum split)**.**

(i) *$\theta_B = \pi/2$ if and only if $r_\perp = 0$ or $r_z = 0$: subspaces are Bures-orthogonal at all diagonal and all equatorial states.*

(ii) *$\theta_B < \pi/2$ if and only if both $r_\perp \neq 0$ and $r_z \neq 0$.*

(iii) *Dephasing monotonically increases θ_B toward $\pi/2$.*

Proof. Parts (i)–(ii) are immediate from (11). For (iii): under dephasing, $r_\perp \mapsto (1-2\gamma) r_\perp$ while r_z is preserved. The numerator of $\cos^2 \theta_B$ decreases monotonically and the denominator increases, so θ_B increases. □

Corollary 3.7 (Estimation-theoretic interpretation)**.** *For a full-rank qubit state, the quantum Fisher information for the population parameter r_z is $[F_Q]_{zz} = (1 - r_\perp^2)/(1 - |\mathbf{r}|^2)$.*

When the coherence parameters are eliminated via the Schur complement [18, 19], the effective Fisher information is

$$[F_Q]^{\text{eff}}_{zz} = [F_Q]_{zz} \sin^2\theta_B = \frac{1}{1-r_z^2}. \tag{13}$$

The Bures separation angle determines the fraction of SLD Fisher information for the population parameter that survives elimination of coherence nuisance parameters.

Proof. The full QFIM is $F_Q = I + \mathbf{r}\mathbf{r}^T/(1-|\mathbf{r}|^2)$. By Sherman–Morrison, $(F_Q^{-1})_{zz} = 1-r_z^2$. The Schur complement gives $[F_Q]^{\text{eff}}_{zz} = 1/(1-r_z^2)$. The ratio $[F_Q]^{\text{eff}}_{zz}/[F_Q]_{zz} = (1-|\mathbf{r}|^2)/[(1-r_\perp^2)(1-r_z^2)] = \sin^2\theta_B$. □

3.2 Generalization to qudits

For d-dimensional systems, there are $d-1$ principal angles between T_ρ^{diag} and T_ρ^{off}.

Theorem 3.8 (Qudit principal angles)**.** *Let $\rho = \text{diag}(p) + C$ be a full-rank d-dimensional state with off-diagonal part C.*

(i) *If $C = 0$, all $d-1$ principal angles equal $\pi/2$ (Theorem 3.4).*

(ii) *Near the simplex ($\|C\|$ small), the cross-Gram matrix has entries*

$$g_B(D_a, R_{kl}) = -\frac{\text{Re}[C_{kl}]}{2(p_k+p_l)}\left(\frac{x_a^k}{p_k} + \frac{x_a^l}{p_l}\right) + O(\|C\|^2), \tag{14}$$

where $D_a = \text{diag}(x_a^1, \ldots, x_a^d)$ is a traceless diagonal tangent vector and $R_{kl} = |k\rangle\langle l| + |l\rangle\langle k|$.

(iii) *For $d \geq 3$: if $\|C\|$ is small and $C \neq 0$, at least one principal angle is strictly less than $\pi/2$.*

(iv) *Under partial dephasing $C_{kl} \mapsto (1-2\gamma)C_{kl}$, the cross-Gram entries scale as $(1-2\gamma)$ at leading order, and all principal angles converge to $\pi/2$ as $\gamma \to 1/2$.*

Proof. Part (ii): Expand $L_a = L_a^{(0)} + L_a^{(1)} + O(\|C\|^2)$. At zeroth order, $(L_a^{(0)})_{kk} = x_a^k/p_k$ with zero off-diagonal entries. At first order, the Lyapunov equation gives $(L_a^{(1)})_{mn} =$

$-C_{mn}(x_a^m/p_m + x_a^n/p_n)/(p_m + p_n)$ for $m \neq n$. For R_{kl}, the first-order diagonal corrections are $(L_R^{(1)})_{kk} = -2\mathrm{Re}[C_{kl}]/[p_k(p_k + p_l)]$. Summing the three first-order contributions to $g_B(D_a, R_{kl})$ yields (14).

Part (iii): For $d \geq 3$ with $C_{kl} \neq 0$, choose D_a with $x_a^k = 1$, $x_a^m = -1$ for some $m \notin \{k, l\}$, zeros elsewhere. Then $x_a^k/p_k + x_a^l/p_l = 1/p_k \neq 0$, giving nonzero cross-Gram. For $d = 2$, the unique traceless direction $\mathrm{diag}(1, -1)$ satisfies $1/p_1 + (-1)/p_2 = 0$ at equal populations, allowing orthogonality; the exact criterion is Theorem 3.5.

Part (iv): Under $C \mapsto (1-2\gamma)C$, equation (14) scales as $(1-2\gamma)$ and vanishes as $\gamma \to 1/2$. □

Theorem 3.9 (Spectator orthogonality criterion for $d \geq 3$)**.** *Let $d \geq 3$ and let ρ be a full-rank state with $\rho_{st} \neq 0$ for some $s \neq t$. If there exists a spectator index $r \notin \{s, t\}$ such that $\rho_{rs} = \rho_{rt} = 0$, then the Bures-orthogonal decomposition $T_\rho^{\mathrm{diag}} \perp_{g_B} T_\rho^{\mathrm{off}}$ fails.*

Proof. For any diagonal X_D and off-diagonal X_O, the SLD metric identity gives

$$g_B(X_D, X_O) = \tfrac{1}{2} \sum_k x_k \, (L_{X_O})_{kk}, \tag{15}$$

so orthogonality requires every off-diagonal SLD to have a flat diagonal.

Since $\rho_{rs} = \rho_{rt} = 0$, the (r, s) and (r, t) entries of the Lyapunov equation for perturbations on the (s, t) block form a homogeneous system with positive determinant, giving $(L_{X_O})_{rs} = (L_{X_O})_{rt} = 0$ and hence $(L_{X_O})_{rr} = 0$.

For the diagonal entry at s:

$$(L_{X_O})_{ss} = -\mathrm{Re}[\rho_{st}(L_{X_O})_{ts}]/p_s. \tag{16}$$

The (s, t) entry of the Lyapunov equation yields a scalar equation for $(L_{X_O})_{st}$ whose solution satisfies $(L_{X_O})_{st} \neq 0$. Writing $\rho_{st} = |\rho_{st}|e^{i\alpha}$:

$$\mathrm{Re}[\rho_{st}(L_{R_{st}})_{ts}] = \frac{2|\rho_{st}| \cos\alpha}{(p_s + p_t)(1 - |\rho_{st}|^2/(p_s p_t))}, \tag{17}$$

$$\mathrm{Re}[\rho_{st}(L_{I_{st}})_{ts}] = \frac{2|\rho_{st}| \sin\alpha}{(p_s + p_t)(1 - |\rho_{st}|^2/(p_s p_t))}. \tag{18}$$

Since $|\rho_{st}| > 0$, at least one of these is nonzero, making $(L_{X_O})_{ss} \neq 0$ while $(L_{X_O})_{rr} = 0$: the SLD diagonal is not flat, so orthogonality fails. $\square$

Conjecture 3.10 (Global orthogonality criterion for $d \geq 3$). For $d \geq 3$, a full-rank state ρ achieves the Bures-orthogonal decomposition $T_\rho^{\text{diag}} \perp_{g_B} T_\rho^{\text{off}}$ if and only if ρ is diagonal in the pointer basis.

Theorem 3.9 proves this conjecture whenever the coherence graph contains an edge whose endpoints share a common non-neighbor. The conjecture extends to fully-coherent states (complete coherence graph). Two rigorous results support the extension: Theorem 3.8(iii) proves it near the simplex for all d, and a numerical survey of random states per dimension ($d = 3, 5, 7$, Figure 1) finds no non-diagonal state achieving orthogonality.

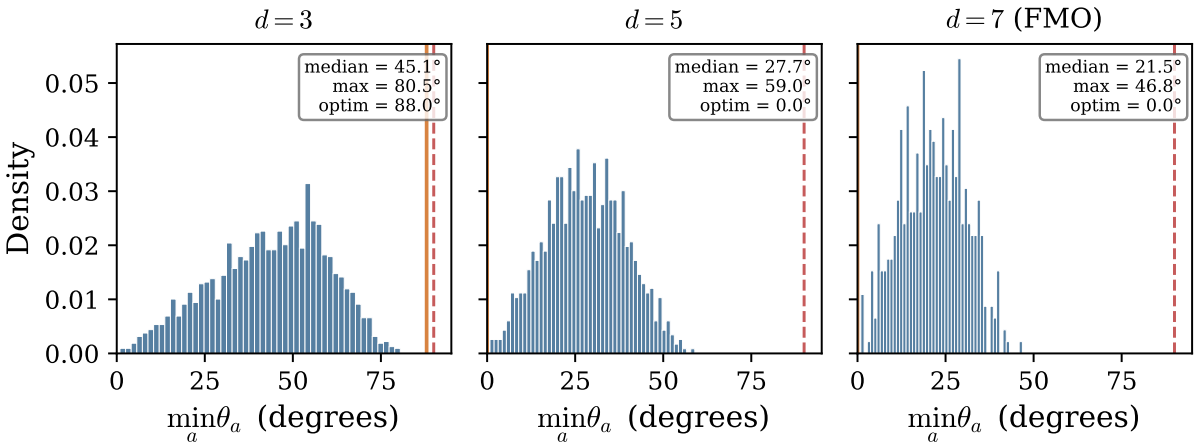

Figure 1: **Numerical survey of qudit principal angles.** For each dimension $d \in \{3, 5, 7\}$, random full-rank density matrices are drawn from the Hilbert–Schmidt measure (blue histogram), and the minimum principal angle $\min_a \theta_a$ between the diagonal and off-diagonal tangent subspaces is computed via the Bures metric. The dashed red line marks 90° (perfect orthogonality). No state approaches orthogonality; the distribution shifts further from 90° as d increases, supporting Conjecture 3.10. The $d = 7$ panel corresponds to the FMO Hilbert space dimension.

4 Thermodynamic Cost of Decoherence

Proposition 4.1 (Free energy of coherence)**.** *Let ρ be a quantum state with system Hamiltonian H. The free energy change under dephasing is*

$$F(\rho) - F(\Lambda_{\text{dec}}[\rho]) = \text{Tr}\Big[(\rho - \Lambda_{\text{dec}}[\rho])H\Big] + k_B T\, C_r(\rho), \tag{19}$$

where $F(\rho) = \mathrm{Tr}[\rho H] - k_B T S(\rho)$ *is the non-equilibrium free energy and* $C_r(\rho) = S(\Lambda_{\mathrm{dec}}[\rho]) - S(\rho) \geq 0$ *is the relative entropy of coherence [20].*

Proof. Direct rearrangement of $F(\rho) - F(\Lambda_{\mathrm{dec}}[\rho])$. Non-negativity of C_r follows from unitality of Λ_{dec} and Schur-concavity of von Neumann entropy. □

When H is diagonal in the dephasing basis, the energy term vanishes and

$$F(\rho) - F(\Lambda_{\mathrm{dec}}[\rho]) = k_B T\, C_r(\rho) \geq 0. \tag{20}$$

The free energy geometrically decomposes along the orthogonal subspaces of Theorem 3.4: the classical component on T_ρ^{diag} and the coherent component on T_ρ^{off}.

For a maximally coherent d-dimensional pure state, $C_r = \ln d$, and the cost per collapsed dimension is $k_B T \ln d/(d^2 - d) \approx k_B T \ln d/d^2$, which vanishes with system size—consistent with the extreme rapidity of macroscopic decoherence [3].

5 Application to Photosynthetic Exciton Transport

5.1 The FMO complex

The Fenna–Matthews–Olson (FMO) complex of green sulfur bacteria (*Chlorobaculum tepidum*) is a trimeric pigment-protein complex that channels excitation energy from the chlorosome antenna to the reaction center. Each monomer contains seven bacteriochlorophyll *a* (BChl *a*) chromophores whose excitonic couplings have been determined spectroscopically [21]. The site-energy Hamiltonian in the site basis (energies in cm^{-1}

relative to $12\,210\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$) is [21]:

$$H_{\mathrm{FMO}} = \begin{pmatrix} 200 & -87.7 & 5.5 & -5.9 & 6.7 & -13.7 & -9.9 \\ -87.7 & 320 & 30.8 & 8.2 & 0.7 & 11.8 & 4.3 \\ 5.5 & 30.8 & 0 & -53.5 & -2.2 & -9.6 & 6.0 \\ -5.9 & 8.2 & -53.5 & 110 & -70.7 & -17.0 & -63.3 \\ 6.7 & 0.7 & -2.2 & -70.7 & 270 & 81.1 & -1.3 \\ -13.7 & 11.8 & -9.6 & -17.0 & 81.1 & 420 & 39.7 \\ -9.9 & 4.3 & 6.0 & -63.3 & -1.3 & 39.7 & 230 \end{pmatrix}. \tag{21}$$

The dominant energy transfer pathways proceed as $1 \to 2 \to 3$ and $6 \to 5/7 \to 4 \to 3$, with site 3 serving as the exit site coupled to the reaction center [21, 9]. Decoherence due to protein-solvent fluctuations occurs on timescales of $\sim 50\,\mathrm{fs}$ at physiological temperature [9], while excitation transfer completes in ~ 1–$5\,\mathrm{ps}$.

5.2 Dimensional collapse in FMO

For the seven-site FMO complex ($d = 7$):

- Full quantum state space: $d^2 - 1 = 48$ real dimensions
- Classical probability simplex: $d - 1 = 6$ dimensions
- Collapse ratio: $1/(d+1) = 1/8 = 12.5\%$

Decoherence annihilates $d^2 - d = 42$ off-diagonal (coherence) dimensions—seven-eighths of the information-geometric degrees of freedom. The surviving 6-dimensional simplex encodes the classical site populations $\{p_1, \ldots, p_7\}$ (with $\sum_k p_k = 1$), which describe the probability of finding the excitation at each chromophore.

Under progressive Haken–Strobl dephasing [22] at rate γ, the density matrix evolves according to the Lindblad master equation

$$\dot{\rho} = -\frac{i}{\hbar}[H_{\mathrm{FMO}}, \rho] + \gamma \sum_{k=1}^{7} \left(|k\rangle\langle k|\rho|k\rangle\langle k| - \frac{1}{2}\{|k\rangle\langle k|, \rho\} \right), \tag{22}$$

where the first term generates unitary evolution (which creates and rotates coherences, and redistributes populations) and the second term dephases coherences at rate γ. In the pure-dephasing limit ($H = 0$), this channel preserves populations and drives off-diagonal elements $\rho_{kl} \to e^{-\gamma t}\rho_{kl}$; the full dynamics (22) is a competition between coherent Hamiltonian evolution and incoherent dephasing.

5.3 Geometry of the quantum-classical split in FMO

Theorems 3.8 and 3.9 establish that for $d \geq 3$, the Bures-orthogonal decomposition $T_\rho^{\text{diag}} \perp_{g_B} T_\rho^{\text{off}}$ fails whenever ρ carries nonzero off-diagonal entries. For the FMO complex ($d = 7$), the diagonal and off-diagonal tangent subspaces have dimensions $d - 1 = 6$ and $d^2 - d = 42$ respectively, and their relative orientation is described by $d - 1 = 6$ principal angles $\theta_1 \leq \cdots \leq \theta_6$.

We compute these principal angles numerically at each dephasing rate γ by evolving (22) from an initial excitation at site 1 for 5 ps, then computing the Bures-metric cross-Gram matrix between diagonal and off-diagonal basis directions and extracting singular values (see Appendix). Figure 2 shows the results.

At weak dephasing ($\gamma \lesssim 1\,\text{cm}^{-1}$), the minimum principal angle drops below 50°: the classical population subspace and the quantum coherence subspace are far from orthogonal, meaning that population parameters and coherence parameters are strongly mixed in the Fisher information sense. At moderate dephasing ($\gamma \sim 5$–$20\,\text{cm}^{-1}$), all angles are in the range 70°–85°: the quantum-classical split is approaching but has not yet reached orthogonality. At strong dephasing ($\gamma > 50\,\text{cm}^{-1}$), all six angles are within a few degrees of 90° and the decomposition is effectively classical.

5.4 ENAQT and the classical limit

ENAQT [7, 6] occurs because pure quantum evolution can trap excitations in interference patterns, while moderate dephasing breaks destructive interference and opens transport channels. The ENAQT optimal dephasing rate for FMO models with a reaction-centre sink is $\gamma_{\text{opt}} \sim 50$–$200\,\text{cm}^{-1}$ depending on model details [7, 9].

Our principal angle analysis places this regime in geometric context. The physiological dephasing range ($\gamma \sim 50$–$200\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$, corresponding to decoherence times ~ 50–$200\,\mathrm{fs}$ at $300\,\mathrm{K}$) falls in the region where all principal angles exceed $89°$ (Figure 2). That is, FMO at physiological conditions is geometrically close to classical: the quantum-classical split is nearly orthogonal. The biologically relevant quantum effects arise from the *small residual departure* from classical orthogonality, not from a regime of strong quantum-classical mixing. The most geometrically interesting transition—where angles pass through $45°$–$80°$—occurs at dephasing rates ($\gamma \sim 1$–$20\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$) well below the physiological range.

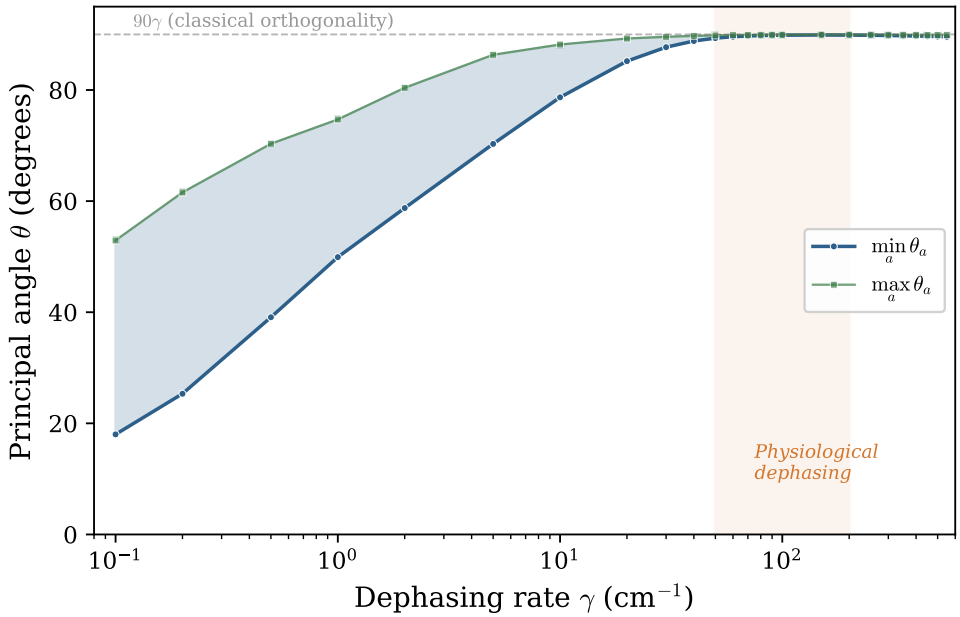

Figure 2: **Bures principal angles in the FMO complex.** The six principal angles $\theta_1, \ldots, \theta_6$ between the diagonal (classical) and off-diagonal (quantum) tangent subspaces of the Bures metric, plotted as a function of Haken–Strobl dephasing rate γ, for the FMO state after $5\,\mathrm{ps}$ of evolution from site 1 excitation. The shaded band spans the minimum to maximum angle. At weak dephasing the subspaces are far from orthogonal (strong quantum-classical mixing); at physiological dephasing rates (shaded region, $\gamma \sim 50$–$200\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$) all angles exceed $89°$ and the system is geometrically nearly classical.

5.5 FMO coupling graph

The coupling structure of the FMO Hamiltonian can be represented as a graph where vertices are chromophore sites and edges connect pairs with significant electronic coupling ($|J_{kl}| > 5\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$). Figure 3 shows this graph. Four site pairs have couplings below the $5\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$ threshold: (2,5), (2,7), (3,5), and (5,7), all involving sites at opposite ends of the

two main transport pathways $1 \to 2 \to 3$ and $6 \to 5/7 \to 4 \to 3$.

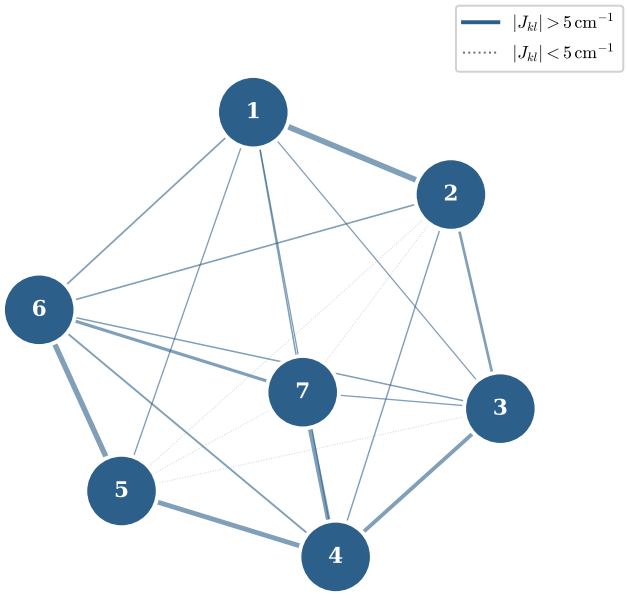

Figure 3: **FMO coupling graph.** Vertices represent the seven BChl sites; edges connect pairs with significant coupling ($|J_{kl}| > 5\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$). Edge widths are proportional to coupling strength. Dotted lines show weak couplings ($|J_{kl}| < 5\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$). The four weak pairs all involve sites at opposite ends of the two main transport pathways.

6 Discussion

6.1 Summary of results

We have shown that decoherence is a dimensional collapse in the information-geometric sense: $d^2 - 1 \to d - 1$ dimensions, with the Bures metric restricting to Fisher–Rao on the surviving simplex. The exact Bures separation angle quantifies the geometry of the classical-quantum split at every full-rank qubit state, and the perturbative theorem and spectator criterion extend the analysis to arbitrary dimension. Applied to the FMO complex, principal angle analysis reveals that at physiological dephasing rates the system is geometrically close to classical (all principal angles within $\sim 1^\circ$ of 90°), while the strong quantum-classical mixing regime lies at much weaker dephasing ($\gamma \lesssim 10\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$).

6.2 Limitations

The qubit separation angle (Theorem 3.5) is exact; for $d \geq 3$, results are partial (spectator theorem + perturbative expansion + conjecture). The Haken–Strobl dephasing model used for FMO is simplified: the real protein-solvent bath has structured spectral density, non-Markovian dynamics, and spatially correlated fluctuations [9]. Our model also omits the reaction-centre sink that is essential for defining ENAQT transport efficiency. Extending the information-geometric analysis to structured baths and to models with explicit trapping is an open problem.

6.3 Outlook: from quantum to classical coherence

A suggestive observation emerges from Theorem 3.3: the Fisher–Rao metric that governs statistical inference on the surviving classical simplex *is* the restriction of the Bures metric from the quantum state manifold. In biological systems, decoherence completes on femtosecond timescales, after which dynamics unfold on the classical simplex. The same information-geometric tools—participation ratio, effective dimensionality, coherence time—apply to both quantum and classical dynamics.

This raises the question of whether biological coherence on longer timescales [23, 24] can be understood as a second stage of dimensional evolution: dissipative dynamics within the Fisher–Rao simplex further shaping the effective dimensionality of accessible states. A rigorous connection would require showing how the information geometry of the quantum-classical transition maps onto effective descriptions of classical biological dynamics. We leave this as a program for future work, noting only that the geometric continuity established by Theorem 3.3 makes such a connection structurally natural.

6.4 Open questions

1. *Conjecture 3.10*: proving that for $d \geq 3$, only diagonal states achieve Bures-orthogonality.

2. *Non-Markovian geometry*: characterizing the dimensional collapse under structured

(non-Markovian) dephasing, where coherence revivals temporarily restore collapsed dimensions.

3. *Multi-chromophore entanglement*: extending beyond single-exciton states to multi-exciton manifolds, where inter-chromophore entanglement adds structure beyond site-basis coherence.

4. *Quantum Darwinism*: the pointer states selected by einselection [3, 25] determine *which* $(d-1)$-dimensional submanifold the collapse targets; the collapse magnitude is basis-independent.

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A Numerical Methods

Random state generation. Full-rank density matrices are drawn from the Hilbert–Schmidt measure: generate a $d \times d$ matrix A with i.i.d. standard complex Gaussian entries, form $\rho = AA^\dagger / \mathrm{Tr}[AA^\dagger]$.

SLD computation. For each tangent direction X, the SLD L_X satisfying $\rho L_X + L_X \rho = 2X$ is computed in the eigenbasis: $(L_X)^{\mathrm{eig}}_{mn} = 2X^{\mathrm{eig}}_{mn}/(\lambda_m + \lambda_n)$.

Principal angles. The $d-1$ principal angles between T_ρ^{diag} and T_ρ^{off} are computed as $\theta_a = \arccos(\sigma_a)$, where $\sigma_1, \ldots, \sigma_{d-1}$ are the singular values of $G_{DD}^{-1/2} G_{DO} G_{OO}^{-1/2}$.

Adversarial search. 100 L-BFGS-B optimizations per dimension maximize $\min_a \theta_a$ over full-rank parameterized states. No optimized state approaches 90°.

FMO dephasing simulation. The Lindblad master equation (22) is integrated numerically using a fourth-order Runge–Kutta scheme with time step $\Delta t = 1.0\,\mathrm{fs}$. The FMO Hamiltonian (21) uses site energies and couplings from Adolphs and Renger [21]. For each dephasing rate γ, the density matrix is evolved from the initial state $\rho(0) = |1\rangle\langle 1|$ (excitation at site 1) for $t = 5\,\mathrm{ps}$, which is sufficient for coherences to reach a quasi-stationary balance between Hamiltonian-driven creation and dephasing-driven decay. (For dephasing rates $\gamma \geq 5\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$, the coherence decay time $\gamma^{-1} \lesssim 1\,\mathrm{ps}$ is shorter than the evolution time.) The state is regularized to full rank ($\rho \mapsto \rho + 10^{-10}\, I/d$) before computing the six Bures principal angles between the diagonal and off-diagonal tangent subspaces.

Software. All computations use NumPy and SciPy. Source code is available in the repository.